

build quality isn't as inspiring. In fact the cheapest phone in the test (LG KG195) is better built, although to be honest this LGs build quality really surprised us, so the Aura i2224 isn't shabby or anything. All these phones are reasonably compact and will fit even the tightest pocket—the KE770 is the slimmest here.

Aside from the LG KE770 and SE's K550i and K530i which have 2 megapixel cameras all the other phones sport lower-end cameras with either VGA or 1.3 megapixel sensors. Intex's IN3333 and LG's KG195 had a surprise waiting—these phones can be used in offline mode, unlike many of the higher-end phones, which need SIM cards to be inserted before the menus become available for use. Although of little use to most, this may be significant to some. Bleu's 466x is a simple phone with no frills save one—it has a full 80 minutes of the famous religious TV serial *Ramayana*—although the screen quality or size isn't too great and we feel this little add-on will be ignored by most users, it merits mention.

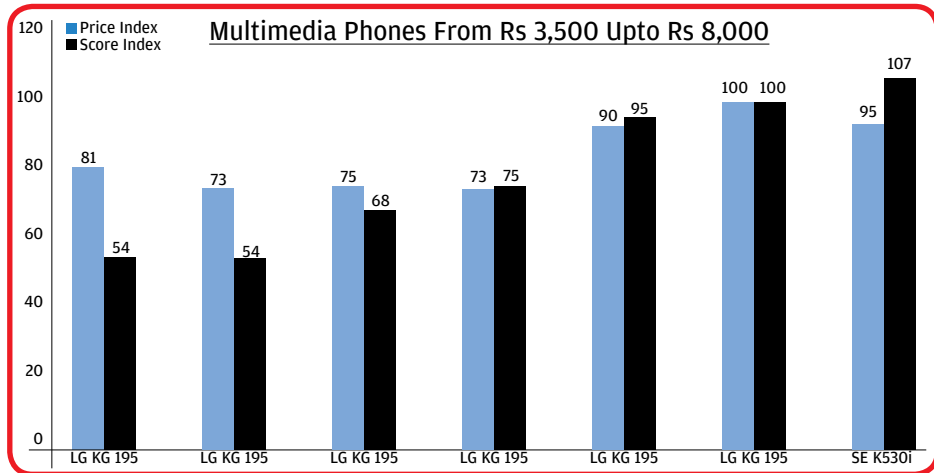
Performance

The LG KE770 and both Sony Ericssons (KE550i and KE530i) have superior cameras, although at this price point you will get very nominal quality from all these phones. What we liked was the call clarity of these three phones, although the KE770 has very limited potential as a music player owing to lower quality sound than both the SE phones.

In the lower half of this category the Intex Aura i2224 battles with the LG KG195 and loses out mainly because the LG is a better performer all round, although the 0.3 megapixel camera will disappoint all camera lovers who buy the KG195. Bleu's 466x and Intex's IN3333 are decent phones, but not at par with some of the others in this price bracket.



SE W380 - One sexy clam



Who Won, And Why?

Our prestigious *Best Buy* award goes to the LG KG195, which at Rs 3,990, is fiercely competitive at its price point. It even manages to steal the limelight away from costlier models in this category. The fact that it is the cheapest phone in the entire test just goes to show that value and performance can coexist.

Smartphone Entry Points

Rs 8,001 to Rs 15,000

This category is perhaps even bigger than the previous one, as quite a few metropolitan people who go cellphone shopping have their sights on this price range. This is because devices in this price range are mostly smartphones, and everybody who has seen one or used one, wants to own one. The average college kid, the teenage with an attitude, the executive making a flashy purchase after saving his first 2 months' salary—all these people are likely to be found seeking a phone in this price range. Here's where the features start to emerge, and the phones start to get bigger, crisper screens, better cameras, more memory, not to mention better build quality and keypads.

Features

The Sony Ericsson W380 caught our attention first. A cute clamshell phone, this one features a

high quality matte purple body with some pink shortcut buttons. Now before you think *Playboy* (the pink does resemble the magazines favourite shade) this phone isn't necessarily aimed at females, a fact which may not become apparent the first time you see it. When we saw other colours of the phone i.e. silver and black, we knew for sure that SE has designed something totally unisexual. The OLED embedded into the front of the phone comes as a shock at first, because looking at the body one expects it to be an opaque fibre, and not translucent. Nevertheless this display is pretty useful when the phone is closed, as it shows you the time, battery status, missed calls, unread SMSes, etc. Besides the utility it's also ultra cool, and adds a little more value. The SE K660 is another excellent looking phone, white with light, fluorescent green trim on the sides. It also feels remarkably solid to hold, and looks like a K850i clone, albeit smaller, and of course much cheaper. Other than the two Sony Ericsson phones the Nokia 5310 Express Music is also noteworthy. It's very slim, in the same league as the sleek Sony Ericsson W890 in this regards, and the body is entirely made of aluminium. The media player buttons on the front bezel, to the left of the screen are very visible, and very usable. Its main shortcoming is the flat keypad that exudes a wooden feedback—SMS junkies beware! LGs KF510

is another sweet looker—made of shiny metal available in glimmering red and black the KF510 is superbly built and has a great slider mechanism. Also worth mention is the Motorola ROKR U9, which is a cute, oval shaped clamshell phone that looks a little like the Motorola PEBL (named because it resembles a pebble, evidently). We'd give the beauty award to the W380 though, and the best build prize would be claimed by the K660—so that's two for Sony Ericsson. Nokia's 5610 Express Music is also available, but this one doesn't impress with its build too much, although the slider quality is good. Nokia's 6500 Classic is another sleek, slim phone with a decent keypad and good build quality—although we didn't like the battery cover's removal procedure—a simple grab and yank cannot be good for the long run, where some sort of play between surfaces is bound to develop. This phone also has 1 GB of inbuilt memory and no memory expansion—a shame considering the falling prices of flash storage. The Samsung D780 is a plain looker, well built, but simple.

The Nokia 5610 and LG KF510 have the best cameras, the resolution of both are 3.2 megapixels. Both also have excellent screens. With VGA resolution video capture the Nokia 5610 does take the lead when it comes to video shooting.

Performance

LGs KF510 has a superb antenna inside and the voice clarity is testament to this—we enjoyed clear call quality even in zone 2 which absolutely butchers cell phone radio signals. In terms of music quality it lags behind though, and both Sony Ericssons and Nokia's Express Music duo outperform it easily. The KF510 does get back in the camera quality tests—understandable since it does have a better camera, and was the only other phone besides the Nokia 5610 to sport an autofocus—which does do wonders for image sharp-

ness. A surprise performer in the music test was the Sony Ericsson W380—this cutie has a great voice too!

Who Won, And Why?

Sony Ericsson's W380 is just too good a phone to pass up—its damn good looking, is suitably feature rich, has great music quality, a very usable keypad, and it's a clamshell—good clamshells are rare! We're awarding it our Best Value award, the absolute clincher for it being the fact that it's the cheapest phone in this category at a price tag of Rs 8,195, and the nearest competitor in terms of price is costs around Rs 1,700 more. This phone makes a superb buy for those looking for a phone without a good camera. If you want a decent camera phone that also has good music quality then you should look at the Nokia 5610 or the LG KF510, we prefer the LG phone though, its much better built. If by chance neither phone attract and you want something solid (not a slider) then take a look at Sony Ericsson's K660—it's a superbly built, solid little thing and also quite feature packed.

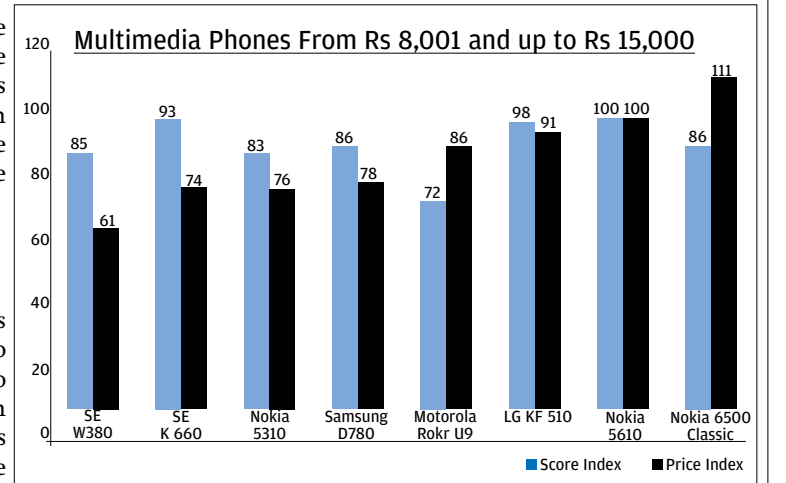
Feature-rich, Fancy Multimedia Phones

Rs 15,000 and up to Rs 19,999

Nokia N78

Wannabe rich-boy's play-toy

Nokia's N78 is another device formed out of the thought process that brought about the N82—a convergence of features, in a nice compact body. Although if you compare features you'll see the N78 bears striking resemblance to the much older N73 instead. With a 3.2 megapixel camera, a sleek body that's slim and ultra compact and a tiny



keypad (sadly) the N78 is one of the best looking, best finished phones we've seen. The steel grey finish is absolutely top class, and the quality of accessories is also excellent—a very good bundle in all. The phone itself sports a great screen that's unfortunately small—2.4 inches is no substitute for a 2.8 inch screen and once you've used the latter, anything smaller seems microscopic.

In terms of connectivity the N78 has it all—WiFi, GPS, superb MP3 player, great camera as well as a snappy processor to get everything done. While the keypad initially looked tiny, it actually works better than the N82, and despite the keys being little more than oblong ridges, you can use this phone without fingernails playing a major role in pressing keys.

At Rs 19,999 just a hairsbreadth separates the N78 from the premium, Rs 20,000 plus category of phones—and in that category itself we must say this phone would hold its own. Its not the best all-round phone, and neither does it have the best camera or the best keypad, but for someone looking for something that's downright handsome, feature rich, and compact you have a definite winner at the price point.



Nokia N78